The Elo Cheat Sheets

THE ELO BLUEPRINT · PRACTICAL REFERENCE · PRINT DOUBLE-SIDED AND KEEP IT NEXT TO YOUR BOARD

The master decision checklist

Run this before every move in a slow game. With practice it takes seconds in quiet positions and you spend your real thinking time where it matters.

CHEAT CODE **Before every move**

1. **What is my opponent threatening?** Ask of their last move: what does it attack, what did it stop defending, what line did it open?
2. **Are any pieces undefended?** Mine *and* theirs. Loose pieces are where tactics happen.
3. **Do I have forcing moves?** Every check, every capture, every threat — for both sides.
4. **What changes after my candidate move?** What does the moved piece stop guarding? Which squares and lines open?
5. **What is my opponent's strongest reply?** Look for their checks, captures and threats against the position *after* your move. Only then play it.

CHEAT CODE **When ahead in material**

1. Remove counterplay first: check the opponent's threats every move.
2. Trade pieces, not pawns (usually). Each trade makes your extra material count for more.
3. Keep your king safe; do not grab more material if it opens your king.
4. Activate your king in the endgame and create a passed pawn.
5. Before every move near the end: **check for stalemate.**

CHEAT CODE **When behind in material**

1. Seek activity: put pieces where they create threats.
2. Keep pieces on the board; avoid trades that simplify into a lost ending.
3. Look for tactical resources: checks, perpetual check, stalemate tricks, forks.
4. Set practical problems — make the opponent find good moves.
5. Do not resign out of frustration; resign only when you would be embarrassed to play on against a strong player.

CHEAT CODE **When you do not know what to do**

1. Which is my worst-placed piece? Improve it.
2. Which enemy piece or pawn is weakest? Attack it.
3. What does my opponent want? Prevent it, if it is cheap to do so.
4. Is there a pawn break that opens lines for my better-placed pieces?
5. Can I safely improve my king (endgame) or make it safer (middlegame)?

COACHING JUDGMENT **How to use heuristics**

Every procedure in this book is a guideline that is right most of the time. The concrete position always wins the argument: if a check, capture or threat changes the picture, calculate it.

1 · The safety scan: blunder prevention

CHEAT CODE **Their last move — three questions**

1. **What does it attack?** Count attackers and defenders on that target.
2. **What did it stop defending?** The piece that moved may have been a guard.
3. **What line did it open?** A moved piece can unmask a bishop, rook or queen behind it.

CHEAT CODE **My candidate move — the blunder check**

1. After my move, list **every check, capture and threat** my opponent has.
2. Does my moved piece **stop guarding** something?
3. Is the destination square **safe**? (attackers vs. defenders, lowest-value attacker)
4. Did I **open a line** to my king or queen?
5. If any answer worries you: pick another candidate.

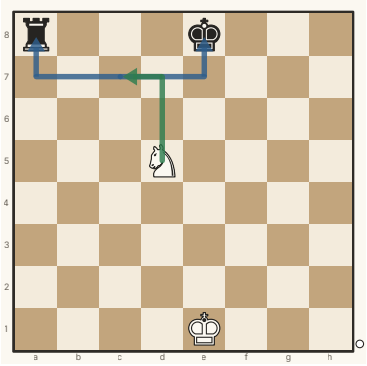
Habit	Why it works
Sit on your hands until the scan is done	Most blunders are moves played before the check was finished.
Say “check, capture, threat” for both sides	Forcing moves are where games are won and lost.
Look at the edges and corners of the board	Long diagonals and edge pieces are the most-missed.
Write the move down before playing it (OTB)	Gives the scan a natural pause.
Play slow games (15+10 or slower)	You cannot build the habit in bullet.

Piece values (a guide, not a law): pawn 1 · knight 3 · bishop 3 · rook 5 · queen 9. A bishop pair is worth a little more in open positions. Activity, king safety and threats can outweigh material.

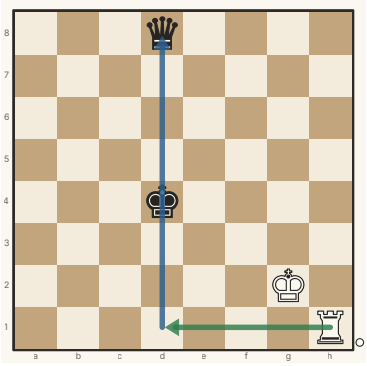
Is it safe to take? Count attackers and defenders on the square; capture with the **lowest-value piece first**; remember that a capture can unmask a new defender (x-ray) or walk into a pin.

2 · Tactics recognition

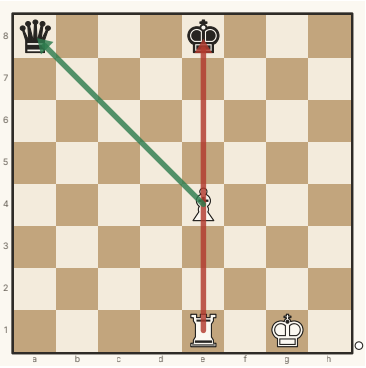
Motif	Trigger to look for	Typical move
Fork	Two loose pieces (or king + piece) a knight’s jump or a queen’s line apart	Knight check that also hits a rook
Pin	Valuable piece behind a less valuable one on a line	Bishop to b5/g5; then attack the pinned piece with a pawn
Skewer	Valuable piece *in front* of a less valuable one on a line	Rook or bishop check; take what is behind
Discovered attack	Your piece sits between your long-range piece and a target	Move the front piece with a threat of its own
Double check	A discovered check where the front piece also checks	King must move — often mate
Removing the defender	One enemy piece guards everything	Capture, chase or block that guard
Overloading	One defender with two jobs	Hit one job; the other collapses
Deflection	A defender that must stay put	Offer material to drag it away
Decoy	A king or queen that would be forkable/matable on another square	Sacrifice to lure it there
Trapped piece	A piece with no safe squares (knight on the rim, bishop on a7/h7)	Take away its last square, then attack it
Zwischenzug	You are “forced” to recapture	First insert a check or bigger threat
Back rank	King behind unmoved pawns, no luft	Rook or queen to the 8th/1st rank



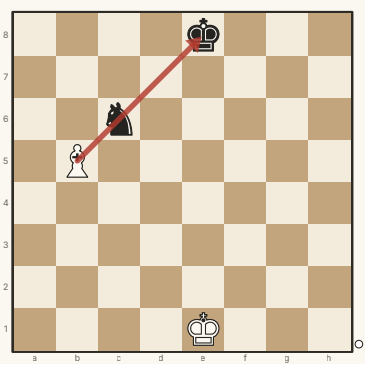
Knight fork — Nc7+ attacks the king and the rook.



Skewer — Rd1+ and the queen behind the king falls.



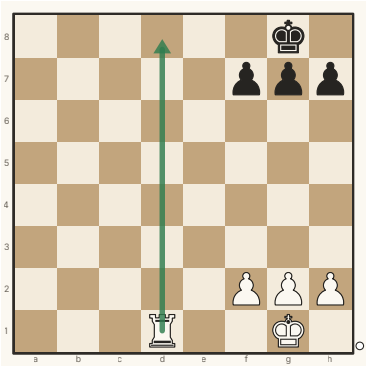
Discovered check — Bxa8+ wins the queen while the rook checks.



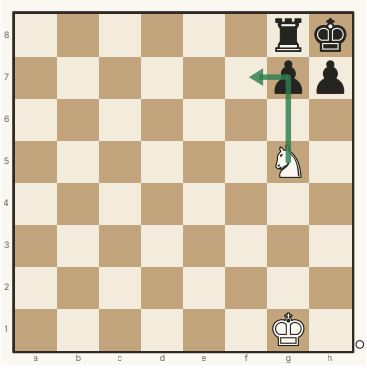
Absolute pin — the c6-knight cannot legally move.

3 · Checkmate patterns

Pattern	Picture
Back-rank mate	Rook/queen on the last rank; king walled in by its own pawns
Smothered mate	Knight mates a king surrounded by its own pieces (Nf7#, often after Qg8+ Rxg8)
Anastasia's mate	Knight on e7 + rook/queen on the h-file vs. a king on h7
Arabian mate	Rook on h7/h8 protected by a knight on f6
Boden's mate	Two crossing bishops vs. a king castled queenside with blocked c- and d-squares
Queen + supporter	Queen lands next to the king protected by a pawn, bishop or knight (Qg7#, Qh7#)
Ladder (lawnmower)	Two heavy pieces taking turns to cut off rank after rank
Légal pattern	Queen sacrifice; three minor pieces deliver mate



Back-rank mate — Rd8#. Prevention: make luft (h3/h6) in time.



Smothered mate — Nf7#. The king's own pieces take every flight square.

4 · Opening principles and your repertoire

CHEAT CODE **The opening in seven rules**

1. Fight for the centre with pawns (e4/d4, …e5/…d5) and pieces.
2. Develop knights and bishops toward the centre; usually knights first.
3. Castle early, usually kingside.
4. Move each piece once in the opening unless there is a concrete reason.
5. Do not bring the queen out early — it gets chased with gain of time.
6. Avoid pointless pawn moves, especially f-pawn moves that open your king.
7. Connect your rooks, then find a plan from the pawn structure.

You play	Against	Your set-up
White	1…e5	2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 — Italian: c3, d3, O-O, Re1, Nbd2–f1–g3, h3
White	1…c5 (Sicilian)	2.c3 (Alapin) — aim for d4
White	1…e6 (French)	2.d4 d5 3.exd5 exd5 — Bd3, Nf3, O-O, c3, Re1
White	1…c6 (Caro-Kann)	2.d4 d5 3.exd5 cxd5 4.Bd3 — c3, Bf4, Nf3
White	1…d5 (Scandinavian)	2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 — gain time on the queen, then d4
Black	1.e4	1…e5 2.Nf3 Nc6; vs 3.Bc4 Bc5; vs 3.Bb5 a6, Nf6, Be7, O-O
Black	1.d4	1…d5 with …e6, …Nf6, …Be7, …O-O, …Nbd7/…c6
Black	London (Bf4)	…Nf6, …e6, …c5, …Nc6, …Bd6
Black	anything else	…Nf6, …d5, …e6, …Be7, …O-O

Traps to know: Scholar's mate (Qh5 + Bc4 vs f7) — defend with …g6 or …Qe7 *before* …Nf6 if the queen is on h5, then chase the queen. Fool's mate — never weaken with f3/f6 + g4/g5. Légal's mate — do not take the queen if it allows three minor pieces to mate. 2…f6? is met by 3.Nxe5!.

5 · Defensive procedures

CHEAT CODE **When something is attacked — the defensive menu**

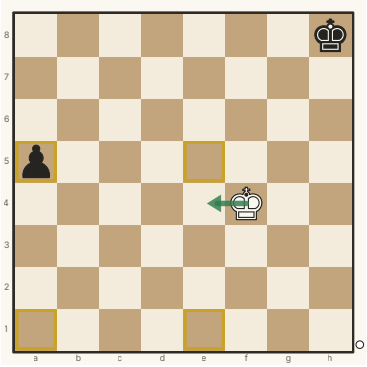
1. **Capture** the attacker (if safe).
2. **Move** the target to a safe, useful square.
3. **Defend** it with a piece (preferably cheaper than the attacker).
4. **Block** the line (interpose), ideally with tempo.
5. **Counter-attack** something bigger — only if you have checked it.

CHEAT CODE **Saving bad positions**

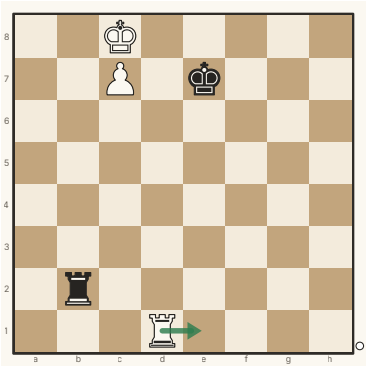
1. Look for **perpetual check** whenever the enemy king is exposed.
2. Look for **stalemate tricks** when your king has no moves.
3. Activate your worst piece; passive defence usually loses slowly.
4. Keep pieces on when behind; trade when it kills their attack.
5. Make every move ask a question.

6 · Endgame essentials

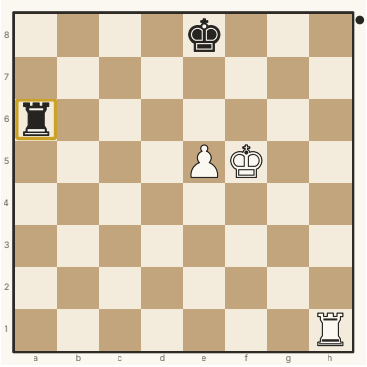
Ending	What to know
K+Q vs K	Restrict the king with the queen a knight's move away; bring your king; **avoid stalemate**
K+R vs K	Shrink the box with the rook; use the opposition; waiting moves
K+P vs K	King in front of the pawn; key squares; opposition; rook pawn often draws
Rule of the square	If the defending king can step into the pawn's square, it catches the pawn
Rook endings	Rook **behind** passed pawns; active rook; cut off the king
Lucena (winning)	Build a bridge: rook to the 4th rank to block checks
Philidor (drawing)	Rook on your 3rd rank until the pawn advances, then check from behind
Opposite bishops	Very drawish with few pawns — but strong for the attacker in the middlegame
Wrong bishop	Bishop + rook pawn whose promotion square is the wrong colour often draws



Rule of the square — White to move steps into the a5-pawn's square (Ke4) and catches it.



Lucena position — White wins by Re1+ and then building a bridge on the 4th rank.



Philidor position — Black keeps the rook on the 6th rank; after e6 it goes behind and checks.

CHEAT CODE **Endgame mindset**

1. Activate the king — it is a strong piece now.
2. Passed pawns must be pushed (and blockaded when they are the opponent's).
3. Do not hurry: improve everything before the decisive break.
4. Count tempi in races — exactly.
5. Before trading into a pawn ending, calculate it to the end.

7 · Practical game plans

Phase	Your job	Common mistake
Opening (moves 1–12)	Develop, castle, fight for the centre, follow your repertoire	Early queen raids, pawn grabbing
Early middlegame	Finish development, connect rooks, find a plan from the structure	Starting an attack with two pieces
Middlegame	Improve the worst piece, target weaknesses, calculate forcing moves	Moving without a reason
Ahead in material	Trade, simplify, stop counterplay	Relaxing and blundering
Behind in material	Activity, threats, complications, perpetual	Passive resignation
Endgame	King activity, passed pawns, technique	Rushing; stalemating

Thinking time. Spend it on critical moments: captures, checks, pawn breaks, trades into endings and whenever the position changes character. Play obvious recaptures quickly after a quick safety scan.

8 · The improvement loop

CHEAT CODE **Learn → Solve → Play → Analyze → Fix → Repeat**

1. **Learn** one skill (one chapter section).
2. **Solve** exercises on that skill; aim for 80 % first-try accuracy.
3. **Play** slow games and try to use the skill.
4. **Analyze** each game *yourself first*: find the turning points and label the mistakes.
5. **Fix**: add each mistake to your journal; turn it into an exercise.
6. **Repeat**: re-solve misses after 1, 3, 7 and 21 days; mix old and new.

Mistake category	Study
hanging-piece	Ch. 3–4 · safety scan every move
missed-tactic	Ch. 7–10, 24 · daily tactics
missed-mate	Ch. 5, 11 · mate patterns
king-safety	Ch. 6, 21
calculation	Ch. 14–15, 24
opening	Ch. 6, 12–13
endgame	Ch. 5, 18, 23, 26
missed-win / conversion	Ch. 16
positional	Ch. 19, 20, 22, 25
time-psychology	Ch. 27